

outside to discuss the need for jihad, nature of jihad, to take revenge for atrocities and insults heaped on Muslims. "It is difficult to be a Muslim in India," Nisar says without elaboration. He never thought, however, that he would end up being a jihadi till about four years ago when he first met Atif at his cousin Shatab's house (Atif was killed in the September 19, 2008 encounter). Atif became friend, philosopher and guide to Shakeel, Nisar, Rehman and others in the gang. The Delhi Police calls him the mastermind of the Delhi serial blasts.

They would often hang out together. "We loved to hear Atif talk about jihad," recalls Nisar, talking of his early association with Atif. Initially, Atif would come with Shatab to meet Nisar; later he started coming on his own. "It was Atif who told me that only a few privileged

unarmed jihadi who was surrounded by Russian tanks in the middle of a desert in Afghanistan. In a desperate bid to save his life, the jihadi threw a fistful of sand he picked up from the ground at the tanks. The sand became a powerful explosive and ripped the Russian tanks apart. "Allah does miracles to save a true jihadi, that's true," Nisar says, his gaze unblinking, believing every word of this fantastic fairy tale.

He remembers that for many months Atif was judging his will and determination and courage to be a jihadi. "For many years Atif did not tell his real intent, the real task for me. He wanted to make sure I could do it," says Nisar, "I always knew I had the fire for jihad." The first time Atif actually defined what he meant by jihad was when he inadvertently mentioned how he placed a bomb at the Sankatmochan Temple in

Varanasi a couple of years ago. Atif told Nisar in graphic detail how he placed the bomb near a tree in the temple premises where four couples were getting married. "It gave me a jolt," says Nisar. "Atif was killing people." But then Atif showed him a larg-

“The jihad is against Maharashtra for ignoring the Srikrishna Report and for what happened in Gujarat.”

ZIA-UR REHMAN



“We loved to hear Atif talk about jihad. He told me that only a few get to wage jihad for Allah.”

SAQUIB NISAR



“I experienced an awakening after I committed my life to Allah. Now life and death are same.”

MOHAMMED SHAKEEL



get to wage jihad for Allah,” recounts Nisar. “He would talk for hours about jihad. He was passionate about it and infused the same in me.”

Nisar says it took a while for him to be completely indoctrinated. Atif prescribed him a reading list of Urdu literature, mostly about the valiant fight of a jihadi against the enemies of Islam. Nisar makes a special mention of the book *Maidan Pukarte Hai*, about the struggle of Afghanistan's Muslims against the Soviet occupation in the 1980s.

The book had a profound impact on him. “The book says that Allah helps a true jihadi, always. And I believe it,” he asserts. Nisar insists on narrating an episode from this book about an

ger reason for all this bloodshed. “Sometimes you have to adopt evil to prevent a bigger one,” he told me. “It’s not for me or you; it’s for Allah.”

Nisar got his first chance to establish his credentials to his immediate group as a true jihadi. He was part of an entourage of 12 sent to plant bombs at Ahmedabad. He did it with no fuss and great success. “After this, we began to meet more often,” said Nisar, “eager to do more jihad. I was particularly close to Atif, Zia and Shatab. Atif liked me; he was impressed by my knowledge of Delhi.” The next opportunity came on September 13. “Atif was worried about our safety that day.” Nisar gives a reason for it. “He did not allow us to carry any identity proof, not even a mobile phone.” That was not for your safety but his own, Nisar was told. “Did Atif use me in the name of Allah?” Nisar thinks aloud, “He did not call me even once after the blasts; he did not insist that I attend the customary congregation at L-18 (the